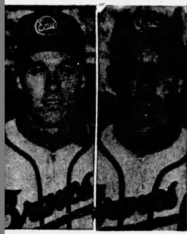


Torre's Play, Classic Loop Features 1960 Baseball Season



Gelein Olson
(Third in a series of reviewing Eau Claire Sports in 1960.)

By CLELL BUZZELL
Joe Torre, the Eau Claire Classic League, and American League expansion to Minneapolis-St. Paul made the biggest baseball news for fans in Eau Claire and Northern Wisconsin in 1960.

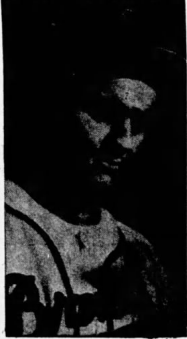
Torre, Eau Claire Braves catcher in the 25th anniversary Northern League season, on the loop batting championship to stand out on a 10th-place club. The Classic League of four Eau Claire teams completed its first season of 27 games and qualified three of its members for the Wisconsin Baseball Assn. tournament at Ithaca.

MAJOR LEAGUE baseball moved to within 80 miles of Eau Claire as the Washington Senators shifted to Metropolitan Stadium and became the Minnesota Twins for the 1961 season.

The new season will find the Twin Cities team joining the interest of baseball-minded people already split among the Milwaukee Braves, Eau Claire Braves, city and area teams in league, Babe Ruth and title League teams, and high school and college nines. Eau Claire area fans suffered as the Milwaukee Braves failed to live up to the me talk by Manager Arley Dressen in a futile result of the Pittsburgh Pirates in the 1960 National League campaign.

The Northern League plans operate in 1961, probably with six teams, despite the arrival of major league baseball inside its far-flung perimeter. The Eau Claire Braves have signed Jim Fanning, former Chicago Cubs pitcher, as 1961 manager.

Torre, 20-year-old rookie, in the Northern League batting championship for 1960 with a .344 mark. He beat out not's Max Alvis by one hit with six hits in 11 trips a twin bill the final day



JOE TORRE

of the season. Torre's batting ability, hustle and all-around play won him Northern League rookie of the year honors and second place in the loop's most valuable player vote. He joined the Milwaukee Braves at the close of the Eau Claire season and made one hit in two trips.

DESPITE THE best catching in years with Dan Newman backing up Torre, Eau Claire was able to do no better than a tie for sixth place. Manager Bill Steinecke's crew hit the skids late in July to plummet from first place to seventh by losing 33 of 44 games.

Lack of consistent pitching and hitting hurt the Eau Claire club. The Braves hit .255, third best in the loop, but left 1,038 runners stranded. Injuries also took their toll, costing the services of 326-hitter Roger Morgan the last month of play.

Hud Gelein, off to a fine start as a home-city southpaw with the Braves, lost his effectiveness before midseason and finished up playing first base. He posted a 9-10 record and 5.08 earned run average, batted .259 and hit three homers.

Best prospects among the Braves besides Torre and Newman were pitchers Paul Chenger, 14-7 and 3.41, and Larry Huebner, 13-9 and 4.26. Torre and Morgan were named to the league all-star team and Steinecke coached in the All-Stars' 4-1 win over Duluth-Superior.

The Braves drew 37,913 fans in 1960, a gain of 2,036 over the previous year in three fewer dates. Bob Quinn, business manager for two years, resigned in October but stayed in the city in private business. Eau Claire



BILL STEINECKE

Fran von Schrader replaced him for 1961.

Eau Claire fans voted for their choice of an all-time all-star team of Braves players in 25 seasons in the Northern League. The contest was sponsored by The Eau Claire Leader and The Daily Telegram.

Named to the honor squad were Andy Cohen, manager; Wes Westrum, catcher; Joe LaFata, first baseman; Hank Majeski, second baseman; Whitey Ries, third baseman; Henry Aaron, shortstop; Bill Bruton, Wes Covington and Stan Spence, outfielders; Georges Maranda, Bob Trowbridge and Don Jordan, right-hand pitchers; and Vic Johnson and Bob Brown, left-hand pitchers.

COHEN WAS elected to the Eau Claire Baseball Hall of Fame. His choice was announced at a banquet introducing Steinecke and attended by Milwaukee officials Dressen, John McHale and John Mullen and coach Andy Patko.

Eau Claire's venture into a four team city league met with good success as Tommy Millers, Twin City Sports, Lake Hallie and Idlewild played a 12-game slate. Tommys won the second round title and a three-game playoff from Twin City, the first-half champion.

Scoring 12 wins in 15 games, Tommys took Classic League honors in most statistical departments. They hit .335 as a team, belted 13 homers, had the leader and runner-up in batting, the five high RBI men, and the four top pitchers in won-lost records and ERA.

Don Amundson won the individual batting title with .403 and Ron Buckli was second with .373. Jim Stolp, Buckli



DON AMUNDSON

and Amundson shared RBI honors with 18 apiece. Stolp led in homers with five. Ken Reitmeyer, Ted Devine, Daryl Wohler and Harv Tomter topped the pitchers, with Devine tossing a no-hitter.

Tommys also won the district semi-pro baseball tournament at Strum and played in the long-delayed state meet at Milwaukee, a make-shift team losing to Ashland in the opener, 3-1. Tommys beat Twin City in the title game at Strum, 10-4. Devine hurled a four-hitter and fanned 18 and Stolp and Gene Garner hit homers to erase a 4-0 deficit. Twin City downed Strum, 13-0, and Tommys nipped Lake Hallie, 5-4, in first-round games.

Tommys, with a 31-7 season record, and Twin City, with 31-16, qualified for the WBA meet. Twin City placed third in Class A and Tommys fifth. Both won their first games and lost their second: Twin City then beat Tommys, 10-4, but lost their title bid in a 17-inning, 13-12 defeat by Spring Valley. New Richmond won the Class A championship. Bob Woletz of Twin City was named most valuable player of the WBA meet.

Lake Hallie, playing in the WBA Class B meet, lost to Hayward in the first round.



BOB WOLETZ

Auburdale won the championship.

Twin City won the first-round title in the Cloverbelt League but lost the playoffs to Greenwood. Tommys copped the Southern Division title in the Chippewa Valley League.

AN ALL-STAR team voted by the Classic League had Jim Stolp, Tommys, first base; Pearly Johnson, Twin City, second base; Gene Garner, Tommys, third base; Ted Lahner, Tommys, shortstop; Ron Buckli and Don Lee, Tommys, and Bob Woletz, Twin City, outfielders; Ted Devine, Tommys, and Ron Haas, Twin City, righthand pitchers; Ken Reitmeyer, Tommys, Bernie Faanes, Lake Hallie, and Larry Bergh, Twin City, left-hand pitchers; Dick Tonnoske, Twin City, utility; and Clyde Sweeney, Tommys, manager.

Eau Claire again staged a Silver Sluggers baseball school sponsored jointly by the Milwaukee Braves and Eau Claire Leader and The Daily Telegram. Harvey Ankley, 18-year-old Rice Lake pitcher, was elected to play in the all-star game at Milwaukee. Terry Olson, Rice Lake pitcher who was the 1959 choice, played briefly



DENNIS O'MELIA

with the Eau Claire Braves in 1960. Other choices were Marty Zichert of Greenwood at Marshfield and Verdell Johnson of Blair at LaCrosse. Eau Claire was host to the WIAA state baseball tournament for the third straight year. Auburdale won its first state title in a 1-0 duel with DePere. Lefty John Baugr, who later signed a bonus contract with the Chicago White Sox, was the star for the Apaches as he pitched two wins, struck out 28 and gave up one run and seven hits in 28 innings.

Eau Claire's Old Abes lost out to Auburdale in the sectional finals. After Bauer had retired 19 straight batters, the Abes rallied for three runs in the last inning but fell short in a 4-3 loss. The Abes had a 9-5 season record. Eau Claire State's Bluebirds, using former pro players for the last time, posted a 7-7 record in the baseball season and a 6-3 mark in Wisconsin College Conference play. LaCrosse won the Northern Division crown, which the Bluebirds had copped in 1959 in a playoff with the Indians.

Eau Claire had a busy season of Babe Ruth and Little League baseball. Twelve teams played in the 12-and-under program and 12 more in the competition for older boys. Two Babe Ruth League all-star teams played in the sectional meet at Superior but were eliminated in the first round. In 1959 the Eau Claire Badgers played in the national meet at Stockton, Calif.

EAU CLAIRE'S American Legion baseball team gained



B. Faanes Garner



Devine Haas

a berth in the state meet at Wisconsin Dells in August. The team lost both games in the double-elimination play, 9-7 to Green Bay and 4-2 to West Allis.

Other developments on the Eau Claire baseball front included:

Re-election of Herman D. White as president and Barney M. Neary as secretary-treasurer of the Northern League at the circuit's annual meeting in Minneapolis in November.

Trade of Bill Bruton, who played his first pro ball here in 1950, by the Milwaukee Braves to the Detroit Tigers. A disappointing season for Dennis Overby, Chetek bonus southpaw, whose brilliant career is jeopardized by shoulder ailment developed at Cedar Rapids last summer and recurring in the Florida Winter Instructional League. Appointment of Bill Steinecke, Eau Claire's 1960 manager, to guide the Wells-ville Braves in 1961.

A no-hit win pitched by Eau Claire's Dennis O'Melia for-Missoula in the Pioneer League. The veteran southpaw whiffed nine in a 2-0 win over Billings.

Len VanDeHey, Eau Claire State veteran, played summer ball in the Man-Dak League and led the circuit with a .380 mark, his second straight batting title.